

BITTEN BY THE TRAVEL BUG

In her free time, Daisy Chittilapilly of Cisco India & SAARC loves building itineraries for the places she wants to visit. And she goes on at least one long vacation every year

BY NIDHI SINGAL

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DUE TO THE demanding nature of their roles and responsibilities, leaders frequently find it challenging to establish boundaries between their personal and professional lives. But that's not the case with Daisy Chittilapilly, President of Cisco India & SAARC. She makes travel itineraries to occupy her in her free time, and she makes it a point to go on at least one long vacation every year. "It's like a hobby of mine to plan and put together itineraries. And when the time is right, I pick that up and go to that place. People do multiple things in their free time; I look at countries I would like to visit and

build itineraries!" she says.

Having visited a number of countries, Chittilapilly adores many destinations, but one country she absolutely loves is Peru—she spent a few weeks exploring it. "It's an amazingly scenic, beautiful place, and the people there are very warm. The food is fantastic.... [And] the culinary experience, unmatched," says Chittilapilly. While she covered many locations across the country, it was the trek to Machu Picchu that made her experience memorable.

Chittilapilly had gone on a four-day trek on the 'Inca Trail' to Machu Picchu, where she found the sunrise over the mountains

especially captivating. She knew the only way to see the sunrise was to walk along the trail, and not go there by train. Determined to see it despite the difficulty, she chose to embark on the journey with seven companions and a guide. "I thought it would be the toughest for me because many people in that group were younger and fitter," she says. But she was one of two people from her group who managed to go the distance. "There were many dropouts on the second day," she adds. Chittilapilly took it slow and steady, and made it to the camps a little later than everybody else.

Covering 45 km in four days isn't usually very daunting, but at an altitude of 13,000-15,000 feet, it can take some doing. "It's about how much willpower it takes to get where you want to go," she says. "You may feel disheartened or discouraged at the prospect of what lies ahead, but if you take it slow and steady, you will make it to your goal; so, you must set your eyes on the finish line," she explains.

Another rejuvenating experience she cherishes from her travels is the delight of meeting new people and learning about them.

